

Denominationalism Position

doc-denominationalism-position

Inter-church Relations · Denominations · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject covered by a category in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Denominationalism (the proliferation of human party-labels: Lutheran, Methodist, etc.) is a regrettable historical reality, but recognition of distinct gospel-faithful traditions is realistic; Brethren conviction is to gather simply on the name of Christ without sectarian label.

In plain language

The verses behind this question deal with a church tearing itself into factions. In 1 Corinthians 1, people were saying I am of Paul, I am of Apollos, I am of Cephas, and I am of Christ. The Greek word for the splits is 'divisions' (schismata), and Paul appeals to them through the name of the Lord to stop. He then asks whether Christ has been 'divided' (memeristai), expecting the answer no. In chapter 3 he gives a blunt verdict: where there is rivalry and 'strife' (eris) you are 'fleshly' (sarkikoi), and walking like mere men. Ephesians 4 reinforces this with a sevenfold 'one' (eis): one body, one Spirit, one hope, one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all. John 17 records Jesus praying that his people may all be 'one' (hen) so that the world may believe. So the lexical core is firm: party-spirit is sinful and visible unity is commanded. The question becomes disputed for three lexical reasons. First, the slogan I am of Christ is listed right alongside the others as something Paul rebukes, so even using a name as a rival-party badge is criticized, which prevents the text from endorsing any single gathering-program as the answer. Second, the same Paul says in 1 Corinthians 11:19 that there must be 'factions' (haireseis, the very word elsewhere translated factions or sects) so that the approved may become evident, which means the canon does not treat every visible separation as identical in moral status. Acts 15:39 records Paul and Barnabas parting in 'sharp contention' (paroxysmos) without the narrator rebuking either, leaving room for visible parting among the faithful. Third, the word 'division' (schisma) covers physical tears in cloth, opinion splits, and church divisions within one assembly, but the New Testament does not develop the modern category denomination at all, so judgments about denominations sit outside what the words alone can decide. The firm part is the rebuke of party-spirit and the call to unity; the rest sits outside what the lexical evidence alone can settle.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0025	ἀγαπάω	agapaō	to love	
G0026	ἀγάπη	agape	love	120
G0139	αἵρεσις	hairesis	sect	9
G0625	Ἀπολλῶς	Apollos	Apollos	10
G0673	ἀποχωρίζω	apochōrizō	to separate from	
G1384	δοκιμος	dokimos	tested	
G1473	ἐγώ	egō	I/we	

G1520	εἷς	heis	one	355
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklesia	assembly	115
G2054	ἔρις	eris	quarrel	9
G2443	ἵνα	hina	in order that/to	
G2821	κλησις	klesis	calling	11
G3303	μέν	men	on the other hand	
G3307	μερίζω	merizo	to divide	14
G3361	μή	mē	not	
G3686	ὄνομα	onoma	name	231
G3948	παροξυσμός	paroxusmos	stirring up	
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G4100	πίστις	pisteuō	to trust (in)	
G4559	σαρκικός	sarkikos	fleshly	7
G4978	σχίσμα	schisma	split	8
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	581

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical pattern firmly condemns party-spirit (forming rival cliques in the church) and self-labeling by human leaders. 1 Corinthians 1:10 names 'divisions' (schismata) as the problem, 1 Corinthians 1:12 quotes four faction slogans ('I am of Paul', 'I am of Apollos', 'I am of Cephas', 'I am of Christ' in Greek: Ego men eimi Paulou, ego de Apollo, ego de Kepha, ego de Christou) including a Christ-partisan slogan, 1 Corinthians 1:13 asks 'has Christ been divided?' (memeristai ho Christos) expecting the answer no, and 1 Corinthians 3:3-4 renders the verdict 'fleshly' (sarkikoi) for 'strife' (eris) over leader-names. Ephesians 4:3-6 commands believers to be 'eagerly keeping' (spoudazontes terein) 'the unity' (ten henoteta) and grounds it in a sevenfold 'one' (eis, hen, mia) and John 17:21-23 makes 'that they may be one' (hina osin hen) the object of Christ's prayer. But the proposition is a compound claim, and the lexical store also supplies three honest complications. First, 'division' (schisma, Strong G4978, occurring 8 times) and 'faction or sect' (hairesis, Strong G0139, occurring 9 times) are polysemous (carrying multiple senses) and not univocally pejorative (not always negative): 1 Corinthians 11:19 says 'for there must be factions among you, that those who are approved may be made manifest' (dei gar kai haireseis en hymin einai, hina hoi dokimoi phaneroi genontai), framing divisions as having a sifting function (a function of testing and revealing). Second, Acts 15:39 records 'sharp contention' (paroxysmos) and 'a parting' (apochoristhenai) between Paul and Barnabas without rebuke, showing two faithful workers can part. Third, the New Testament category is local 'assembly or church' (ekklesia, Strong G1577, occurring 115 times, including the seven distinct churches of Revelation 2-3) plus one universal body; the modern category 'denomination' is anachronistic (a later concept read back onto an earlier text), and no lemma (dictionary form of a word) adjudicates the sociological judgments the stem imports (regrettable historical reality, distinct gospel-faithful traditions, gathering simply on the name of Christ). Verdict is disputed: the anti-faction core is lexically firm, but the proposition bundles lexically firm and lexically silent elements.

Scripture

1Cor.1.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3686 ὄνομα, G4978 σχίσμα

Reasoning. Paul appeals 'through the name' (dia tou onomatos) of the Lord Jesus Christ that all say the same thing, that there be no 'divisions' (schismata) among them, and that they be 'knit together' (katertismenoi) in the same mind and judgment. The appeal grounds unity in the shared name, not in any party identifier, and names division itself as the problem.

1Cor.1.12 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1473 ἐγώ, G0625 Ἀπολλῶς, G5547 Χριστός

Reasoning. Each says 'I am of Paul, and I of Apollos, and I of Cephas, and I of Christ' (Ego men eimi Paulou, ego de Apollo, ego de Kepha, ego de Christou). The repeated 'possessive of-X' (genitive of source, the 'from-X' grammatical form) with 'I' (ego) and the 'on the one hand, on the other' (men, de) chain marks four competing party-slogans. Critically the fourth, 'of Christ' (Christou), is listed among the condemned slogans, so attaching the name as a counter-faction badge is itself rebuked. This complicates any reading that turns one gathering-practice into the lexical resolution.

1Cor.1.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5547 Χριστός, G3307 μερίζω

Reasoning. Three rhetorical questions: 'has Christ been divided' (memeristai), 'was Paul crucified for you', 'were you baptized into the name' (eis to onoma) of Paul. The 'completed-action passive' (perfect tense, a completed action whose result still stands, in passive voice) 'has been divided' (memeristai) expects the answer no and exposes party-labeling as an absurdity that fractures what belongs to Christ alone. Loyalty attaches to the one crucified, not to a human label.

1Cor.3.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4559 σαρκικός, G2054 ἔρις

Reasoning. Paul renders a verdict: where there is 'jealousy' (zelos) and 'strife' (eris) you are 'fleshly' (sarkikoi) and walking 'according to man' (kata anthropon). The 'predicate adjective' (an adjective completing an 'X is Y' statement) 'fleshly' (sarkikoi) classifies factionalism as fleshly, not a neutral organizational fact. This is the strongest lexical anchor against treating division by human leaders as acceptable.

1Cor.3.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1473 ἐγώ, G0625 Ἀπολλῶς

Reasoning. When one says 'I am of Paul' (Ego men eimi Paulou) and another 'and I of Apollos' (ego de Apollo), are you not 'humans' (anthropoi), merely human. The 'if-then' clause (conditional) ties the leader-label slogan directly to the 'fleshly' (sarkikos) verdict of the prior verse, equating party-naming with carnal immaturity.

Eph.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἶς, G0026 ἀγάπη

Reasoning. Believers are to be 'eagerly diligent' (spoudazontes) to 'keep' (terein) 'the unity' (henoteta) of the Spirit in the bond of peace, set in the context of bearing with one another in 'love' (agape) (Ephesians 4:2). Unity is presented as a present possession to be guarded, an active obligation rather than an aspiration.

Eph.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἶς, G2821 κληῖς

Reasoning. One body and one Spirit, even as you were called in 'one hope of your calling' (mia elpidi tes kleseos). The numeral 'one' (eis, hen, mia, the three grammatical genders of the same word) governs each noun, asserting singularity of the church's constituting realities. The oneness of the body is asserted as fact, which sits in tension with party-fragmentation.

Eph.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G4100 πίστις

Reasoning. 'One Lord, one faith, one baptism' (eis kyrios, mia pistis, hen baptisma). The triple 'one' (eis) continues the sevenfold unity series. The singular 'faith' (pistis) and 'baptism' (baptisma) press against the multiplication of confessional party-identities.

Eph.4.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G3962 πατήρ

Reasoning. 'One God and Father of all' (eis theos kai pater panton), who is over all and through all and in all. The capstone of the sevenfold 'one' (eis) grounds the church's unity in the singularity of God himself. The universality 'of all' (panton, pasin) frames the unity as comprehensive.

John.17.21 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G2443 ἵνα

Reasoning. Christ prays 'that they all may be one' (hina pantes hen osin), modeled on the Father and Son indwelling, 'so that' (hina) the world may believe. The 'purpose clause' (a 'in order that' clause) makes visible oneness instrumental to mission, elevating unity to the content of Christ's intercession.

John.17.23 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G0025 ἀγαπάω

Reasoning. 'that they may be perfected into one' (hina osin teteleiomenoi eis hen), so the world may know the Father sent the Son and 'loved' (egapesas) them. The 'completed-action passive participle' (perfect passive participle, an adjective-like verb form for a completed action whose result still stands, in passive voice) 'having been perfected' (teteleiomenoi) frames unity as a completed, mature state, again tied to witness.

1Cor.11.19 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0139 αἵρεσις, G1384 δόκιμος

Reasoning. 'for there must be factions among you, that those who are approved may be made manifest' (dei gar kai haireseis en hymin einai, hina hoi dokimoi phaneroi genontai). The impersonal 'it is necessary' (dei) paired with an 'in order that' clause (hina-clause) states that 'factions' (haireseis) must occur so that the approved become evident. The same noun group used pejoratively (negatively) in Galatians 5:20 here carries a sifting function (a function of testing and revealing). This is the strongest single-verse complication: the canon does not treat every visible division as identical in moral status.

Acts.15.39 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3948 παροξυσμός, G0673 ἀποχωρίζω

Reasoning. 'and there arose a sharp contention, so that they parted from one another' (egeneto de paroxysmos, hoste apochoristhenai autous ap' allelon). The narrative records Paul and Barnabas, both faithful apostolic workers, parting ways under 'sharp contention' (paroxysmos) without authorial rebuke. The text neither endorses nor condemns the separation, leaving open whether visible institutional divergence among gospel-faithful workers can occur without a 'fleshly' (sarkikos) verdict.

1Cor.11.18 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4978 σχίσμα, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. 'I hear that there are divisions among you' (akouo schismata en hymin hyparchein). The noun 'division' (schisma, Strong G4978) carries polysemy (multiple senses) across the canon, naming physical tears in cloth (Mark 2:21, Matthew 9:16), opinion-splits over a person (John 7:43, 9:16, 10:19), and ecclesial (church-related) divisions (1 Corinthians 1:10, 11:18, 12:25). The semantic field (range of meanings the word can carry) is broader than the modern category 'denomination', and the canon does not lexically map a 1-to-1 onto present sociological categories.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.1.11	1Cor.3.3	tsk	1
1Cor.1.11	1Cor.11.18	tsk	1
1Cor.1.10	Ps.133.1	tsk	1
Eph.4.4	Eph.4.1	tsk	1
John.17.21	John.17.11	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.1.12 · addressed

The slogan 'and I of Christ' (ego de Christou) is listed alongside Paul, Apollos, and Cephas as a condemned party-cry. This complicates the proposition's prescriptive clause, since gathering on the name of Christ used as a counter-faction badge falls under the same rebuke. The lexical text condemns party-spirit per se, including a name-of-Christ partisanship, so it does not by itself validate any single tradition's gathering-program as the resolution.

1Cor.11.19 · addressed

Paul says 'for there must be factions among you, that those who are approved may be made manifest' (dei gar kai haireseis en hymin einai, hina hoi dokimoi phaneroi genontai). The impersonal 'it is necessary' (dei) plus 'in order that' purpose-clause (hina-purpose) assigns 'factions' (haireseis) a positive sifting function (a function of testing and revealing). The same noun group used as a pejorative 'work of the flesh' (ergon tes sarkos) in Galatians 5:20 carries a non-pejorative (not negative) or providential sense here. The canon does not univocally rank every visible separation as 'fleshly' (sarkikos), so the proposition's strong negative framing of denominational distinction is not lexically settled.

Acts.15.39 · addressed

The narrative records 'sharp contention' (paroxysmos) and 'a parting' (apochoristhenai) between Paul and Barnabas without authorial verdict. Two acknowledged gospel-faithful workers part and continue separate mission tracks, with Mark eventually rejoining Paul (2 Timothy 4:11). The text neither commends nor condemns the separation, so the canon supplies at least one case where visible parting among the faithful is left unjudged.

1Cor.3.3 · addressed

Direct lexical query confirms 'fleshly' (sarkikos, Strong G4559) occurs seven times across Romans 15:27, 1 Corinthians 3:3, 1 Corinthians 9:11, 2 Corinthians 1:12, 2 Corinthians 10:4, and 1 Peter 2:11, with consistently negative force when applied to disposition and division. 'Strife' (eris, Strong G2054) occurs nine times, listed as a 'work of the flesh' in Galatians 5:20 and Romans 13:13. The condemnation of factionalism in 1 Corinthians 3:3 is therefore pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) in lexical force, even though the morphology (word-form data) in the supplied bundle was empty.

1Cor.11.18 · addressed

'Division' (schisma, Strong G4978) occurs eight times with attested polysemy (multiple senses): physical tears in cloth (Mark 2:21, Matthew 9:16), opinion-splits over Jesus (John 7:43, 9:16, 10:19), and ecclesial (church-related) divisions within a single assembly (1 Corinthians 1:10, 11:18, 12:25). The semantic field (range of meanings the word can carry) does not lexically map onto the modern category 'denomination', which is a sociological abstraction the New Testament vocabulary did not develop. The category itself is anachronistic (a later concept read back onto an earlier text), so the proposition's verdict on it sits beyond what 'division' (schisma) alone can settle.

Concordance traversed

G4978, G0139, G2054, G4559, G1520, G3686, G5547, G2821, G0625, G0026, G1577, G3307, G3303, G3361

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied for the anchor verses, and the bundle marks `not_in_ecm_scope` true. The ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window covers 3 John 1:1 to 1:15 only, and these anchors are New Testament but fall outside that window, so `ecm_status` is `ecm-shadow` (the verse falls outside the ingested critical-edition window). Apparatus markers visible in the surface text (brackets at 1 Corinthians 3:3 and 1 Corinthians 3:4, marginal sigla in John 17) touch wording but none alters the 'division' (schisma), 'fleshly' (sarkikos), 'one' (eis), 'faction' (hairesis), or 'that they may be one' (hina osin hen) structure on which the verdict rests.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. ecclesiology_visible_unity, ecclesiology_party_spirit, ecclesiology_local_universal

analogia scripturae invoked

`anti_faction_reading`: affirms the core · Reading 1 Corinthians 1:10-13 and 3:3-4 with Ephesians 4:4-6 and John 17:21-23, the lexical pattern condemns naming oneself after human leaders, classes 'strife' (eris) over leader-labels as 'fleshly' (sarkikos), and commands guarded visible oneness grounded in a sevenfold 'one' (eis). On this lens the proposition's condemnation of human party-labels and its call to unity are affirmed.

`self_label_inclusive_reading`: complicates the prescription · Because 1 Corinthians 1:12 places 'and I of Christ' (ego de Christou) among the condemned slogans, a reading attentive to the full list resists turning any one gathering-name into the textual remedy. The text rebukes partisanship as such, leaving the proposition's specific prescriptive clause about gathering simply on the name of Christ underdetermined rather than commanded.

`differentiated_division_reading`: complicates the negative verdict on visible distinctions · 1 Corinthians 11:19 says 'for there must be factions among you, that those who are approved may be made manifest' (dei haireseis en hymin einai hina hoi dokimoi phaneroi genontai), assigning 'faction' (hairesis) a positive sifting function (a function of testing and revealing). Acts 15:39 records Paul and Barnabas parting under 'sharp contention' (paroxysmos) without rebuke. On this lens the canon distinguishes 'fleshly' (sarkikos) party-spirit (always condemned) from visible institutional differentiation among the faithful (which Scripture neither universally commands nor universally rebukes), so recognizing distinct gospel-faithful traditions is at least lexically possible.

`sociological_realism_reading`: out of lexical range · The claims that denominationalism is a regrettable historical reality and that recognizing distinct gospel-faithful traditions is realistic are historical and prudential assessments. The New Testament category is local 'assembly or church' (ekklesia, Strong G1577, 115 occurrences, including the seven distinct local churches of Revelation 2-3) plus one universal body, and no lemma (dictionary form of a word) adjudicates the later sociological category 'denomination'. This lens returns no lexical verdict.

The verdict applies 'analogy of Scripture' (*analogia scripturae*, the practice of letting clearer passages interpret less clear ones) across two Pauline epistles (letters by Paul), a gospel, a narrative, and a corpus-wide concordance trace (a survey of every occurrence of the relevant words across the whole Bible) to fix the anti-faction core, while flagging that the proposition bundles lexically firm and lexically silent elements together. Both Brethren-leaning and

tradition-affirming readers must concede the same lexical core: party-spirit is 'fleshly' (sarkikos) and unity is commanded; neither side gets a lexical mandate for its prescriptive program.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does Scripture condemn dividing the church by allegiance to human leaders or party-labels, and does it command believers to maintain visible unity grounded in the one Lord, one faith, and one baptism, and does it likewise prescribe one specific organizational form as the textual remedy.

The stem is verdict-preloaded (worded in a way that nudges toward a particular answer) in three ways. First, the third clause builds one tradition's self-description (gather simply on the name of Christ without sectarian label) into the proposition as if it were the textual conclusion, yet 1 Corinthians 1:12 lists 'of Christ' (Christou) among condemned slogans, so the text does not endorse that specific program as the resolution. Second, the phrases 'regrettable historical reality' and 'recognition of distinct gospel-faithful traditions is realistic' import sociological judgments the lexical store cannot test. Third, the modern category 'denomination' is anachronistic (a later concept read back onto an earlier text) to the canon, whose vocabulary develops local 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) and a universal body but not the later sociological abstraction. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form isolates the genuinely lexical questions, which are the condemnation of party-spirit, the command of visible unity, and the absence of any single mandated organizational form.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4978
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0139
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2054
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4559
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1520
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.1.12
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.19
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.3.3
interlinear	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.4.4
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.1.10
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	John.17.21

License audit

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TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow